That reaction is exactly what makes *Satluj* more than a censorship story. The film revives, in the starkest terms, a debate Punjab has not fully had in public: who gets to be remembered as a martyr, who as a mass murderer, and who decides. Its hero is Jaswant Singh Khalra, the human rights activist who brought to light the police's extra-judicial methods. Its villains are two men most credited with ending Khalistani terrorism, Punjab's Director General of Police (DGP) K.P.S. Gill and Chief Minister Beant Singh, the former especially looked up to, even beyond Punjab, for restoring peace after nearly a decade of bloodshed. Both readings turn out to hold some truth: that Khalra was a fearless truth-teller who paid with his life for exposing the clandestine cremations of "unidentified" young Sikhs, and that the film conveniently erases the terrorist violence that provoked the state's response in the first place. Coming just months ahead of an assembly election, the timing has made the film as much a political flashpoint as a cinematic one. What follows sets the film against the historical record.

Whose Truth is It?

Satluj portrays the courageous life of Khalra (played by Dosanjh) who pursued what he believed were scores of summary executions of young Sikhs by Punjab Police, and the surreptitious disposal of their bodies as "unidentified" in three border-town cremation grounds—Amritsar, Patti and Tarn Taran—that bore the brunt of Khalistani terrorism at the time. The film, which its makers say is based on true events and court records, is unsparing toward the fictional proxies representing Gill and Beant Singh. By design, this sharpens the protagonist's courage.

It is also apparently by design that the filmmakers suppress any mention of Khalra's own Khalistani sympathies. Officially general secretary of the Shiromani Akali Dal's human rights cell, Khalra has been recorded praising Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale—killed in Operation Bluestar—as a "*qaumi* hero whose sacrifice has redefined the Sikhs' relationship with India". In 1992, he claimed that some 50,000 Sikh "freedom fighters" had died pursuing a separate state, compared Indira Gandhi's assassins Satwant Singh and Kehar Singh to Bhagat Singh and Kartar Singh Sarabha and, in an article he edited for the magazine *Liberation Khalistan*, called them "*Khalistani heeray* (diamonds)". Yet there is no evidence that Khalra himself joined any militant organisation or was publicly linked to the killing of any of the thousands of civilians targeted by Khalistani terrorists.

2,097

PERSONS

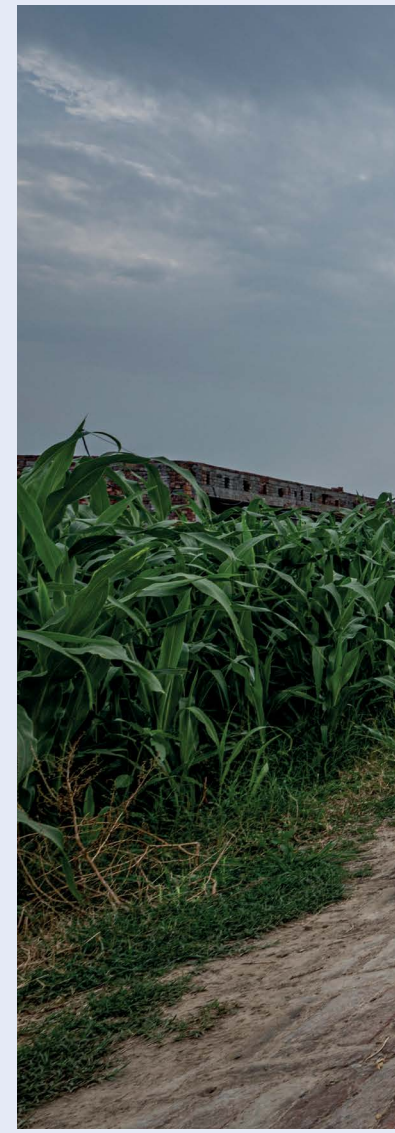
whose unidentified bodies were cremated in just three police jurisdictions that *Satluj* showcases

5,265

PUNJABIS

Civilians, militants, cops killed in 1991, the peak year of terrorist violence

All agree that *Satluj* offers a narrowly focused retelling of Khalra's final years, powerful even if it takes one side. But some are far more scathing, saying it is built on "wilful and partisan falsehoods". According to Ajai Sahni, executive director of the Institute for Conflict Management and the South Asia Terrorism Portal, Khalra "would correctly be described not as a human rights activist, but as an overground worker or a terrorist associate", whose antecedents and ideology the film entirely ignores. The filmmakers stick closely to Khalra's own claim of 25,000 illegal cremations of unidentified Sikh youth across Punjab—a figure extrapolated from the 2,097 cremations he documented at Amritsar's Durgiana Mandir and municipal crematoria in Patti and



CASE STUDY

Four Faces of Loss

Jagir Kaur does not hold a framed family photograph. She holds a poster. On it are four faded faces: her ex-serviceman husband Piara Singh, son Harphool Singh who was just about to join Punjab Police as a constable, nephew Gurdeep Singh and a relative, Swaran Singh. The paper has yellowed, but she keeps it close—the faces